IESE Business School
University of Navarra



Susan Wojcicki:
Leading in an Uncertain World

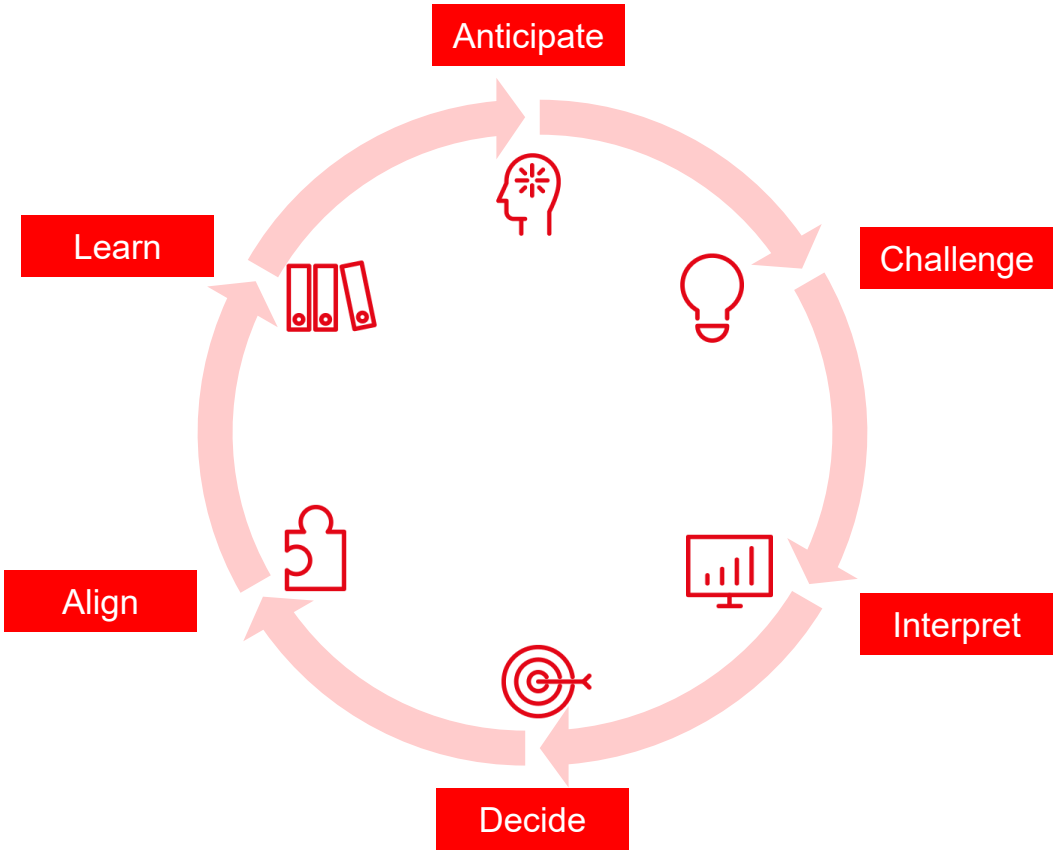
MiM 2025 - sabel Villamor

VUCA Context



Source: Bennett & Lemoine (2014)

Six leadership disciplines needed for VUCA



Source: Schoemaker, Heaton, & Teece (2018)

Which One Do YOU Handle Best? Which One Challenges YOU the Most?

Anticipate	Look for game-changing information at the periphery Search beyond current boundaries Build wide networks to help teams scan the horizon
Challenge	Reframe problems to understand root causes Challenge current beliefs and mind-sets Uncover hypocrisy, manipulation, and bias
Interpret	Seek to understand patterns from multiple data points Engage others to weigh, filter, and develop insights Check for decision biases and test multiple hypotheses
Decide	Carefully frame the decision and approach Balance speed, rigor, quality, and agility Make (asset light) commitments even with incomplete information
Align	Understand what drives diverse agendas and is hidden Ensure tough issues are surfaced to pinpoint misalignment Provide a compelling strategic vision
Learn	Encourage and exemplify transparent, rigorous debriefs Stay agile and course-correct quickly if off track Celebrate success and the right kind of failures

Source: Schoemaker, Heaton, & Teece (2018)



Failing Is Hard, but Not Near as Hard as Learning From It



A Spectrum of Reasons for Failure

Which of the potential causes of failure do you consider blameworthy?

What percent of the failure in your organization/team/family can be considered blameworthy?

How many of these failures are treated as blameworthy by those who matter in your organization/team/ family?

Praiseworthy — Blameworthy

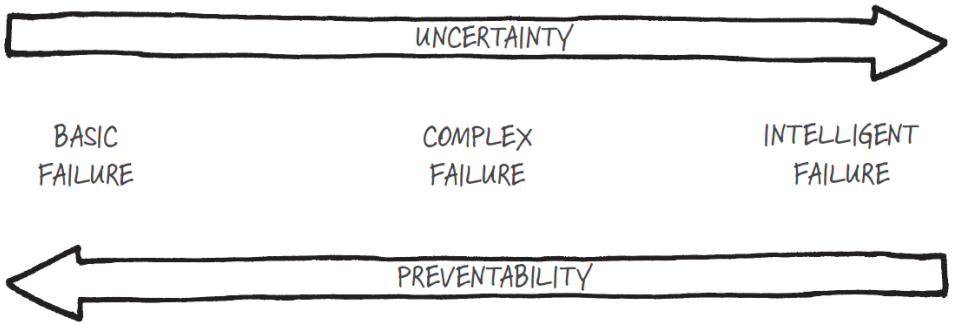


Exploratory Testing	Hypothesis Testing	Uncertainty	Process Complexity	Task Challenge	Process Inadequacy	Lack Of Ability	Inattention	Deviance
An experiment conducted to expand knowledge/ investigate a possibility leads to an undesired result	An experiment conducted to prove that an idea or a design will succeed fails	A lack of clarity about future events causes people to take seemingly reasonable actions that produce undesired results	A process composed of many elements breaks down when it encounters novel interactions	An individual faces a task too difficult to be executed reliably every time	A competent individual adheres to a prescribed but faulty or incomplete process	An individual doesn't have the skills, conditions, or training to execute a job	An individual inadvertently deviates from specifications	An individual chooses to violate a prescribed process or practice

Source: Edmondson (2023)

Implications of Context for Failure

Types of Failure & Relationship to Context

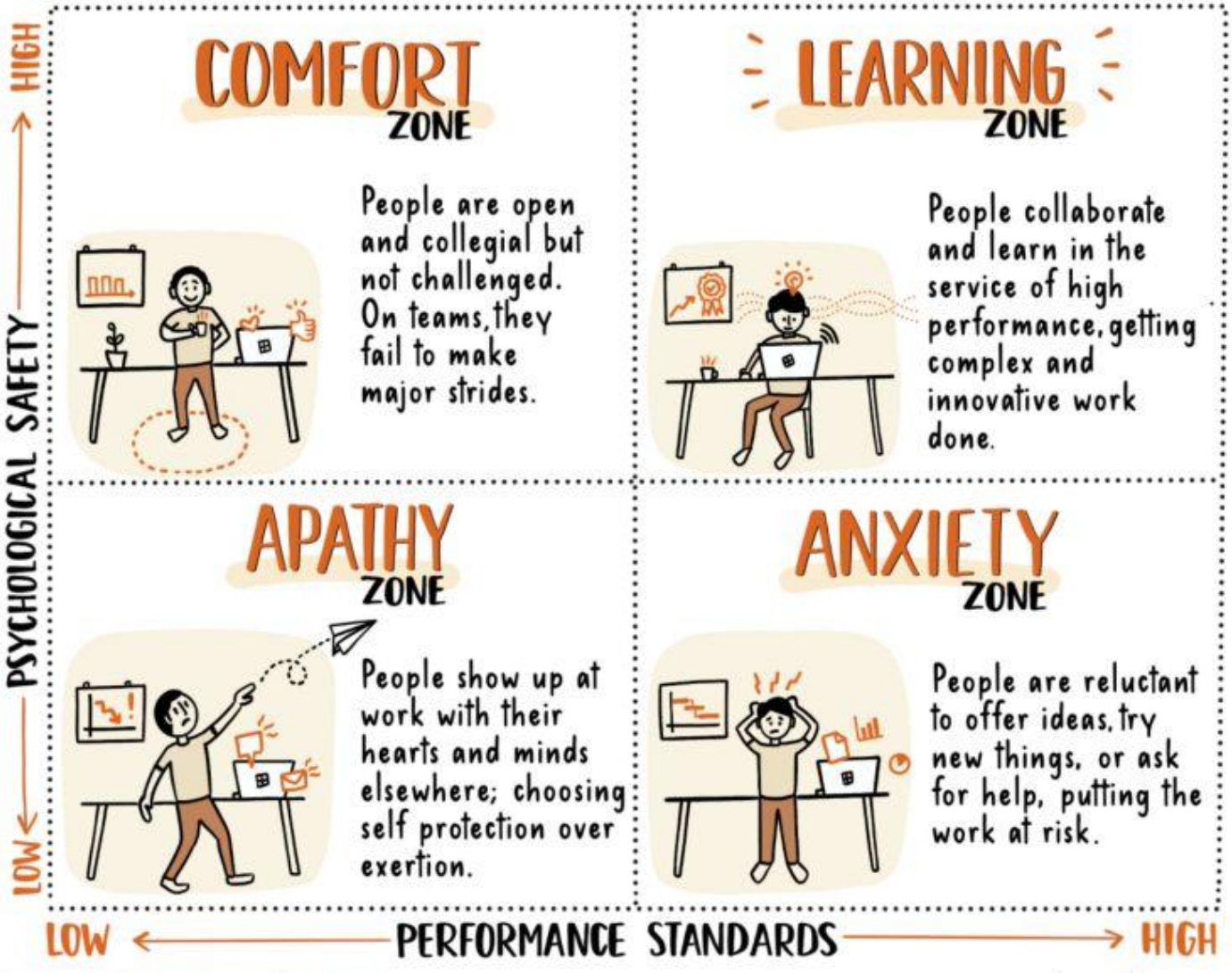


Context	Consistent	Variable	Novel
Example	Vehicle assembly line	Surgical operating room	Scientific laboratory
The state of knowledge	Well-developed	Well-developed knowledge, vulnerable to unexpected events	Limited

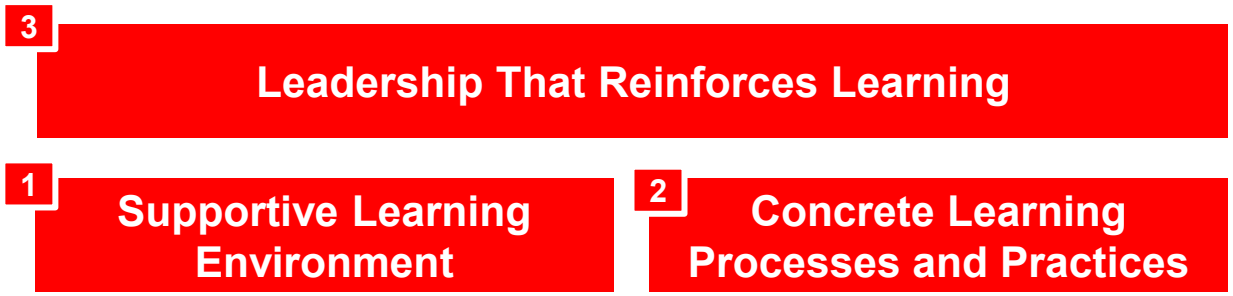


Source: Edmondson (2023)

How psychological safety relates to performance standards



Is Yours a Learning Organization?



Source: Garvin, Edmondson & Gino (2008)

Is Yours a Learning Organization?

3 Leadership That Reinforces Learning

1 **Supportive Learning Environment**

- Psychological Safety
- Appreciation of Differences
- Openness to New Ideas
- Time for Reflection



Blameless reporting

- Errors -> accidents
- Investigations -> analysis

Source: Garvin, Edmondson & Gino (2008)

Is Yours a Learning Organization?

3 Leadership That Reinforces Learning



1. *What did we set out to do?*
2. *What actually happened?*
3. *Why did it happen?*
4. *What do we do next time?*

CENTER FOR ARMY LESSONS LEARNED
SINCE 1985
CALL

2 **Concrete Learning Processes and Practices**

- Experimentation
- Information Collection
- Analysis
- Education and Training
- Information Transfer

Source: Garvin, Edmondson & Gino (2008)

Is Yours a Learning Organization?

3 **Leadership That Reinforces Learning**

1 **Supportive Learning Environment**

2 **Concrete Learning Processes and Practices**

Source: Garvin, Edmondson & Gino (2008)

Assess the Depth of Learning in Your Organization

BUILDING BLOCK 1

Supportive Learning Environment

Psychological Safety

In this unit, it is easy to speak up about what is on your mind.

If you make a mistake in this unit, it is often held against you.*

People in this unit are usually comfortable talking about problems and disagreements.

People in this unit are eager to share information about what does and doesn't work.

Keeping your cards close to your vest is the best way to get ahead in this unit.*

Appreciation of Differences

Differences in opinion are welcome in this unit.

Unless an opinion is consistent with what most people in this unit believe, it won't be valued.*

This unit tends to handle differences of opinion privately or off-line, rather than addressing them directly with the group.*

In this unit, people are open to alternative ways of getting work done.

Openness to New Ideas

In this unit, people value new ideas.

Unless an idea has been around for a long time, no one in this unit wants to hear it.*

In this unit, people are interested in better ways of doing things.

In this unit, people often resist untried approaches.*

Time for Reflection

People in this unit are overly stressed.*

Despite the workload, people in this unit find time to review how the work is going.

In this unit, schedule pressure gets in the way of doing a good job.*

In this unit, people are too busy to invest time in improvement.*

There is simply no time for reflection in this unit.*

BUILDING BLOCK 2

Concrete Learning Processes and Practices

Experimentation

This unit experiments frequently with new ways of working.

This unit experiments frequently with new product or service offerings.

This unit has a formal process for conducting and evaluating experiments or new ideas.

This unit frequently employs prototypes or simulations when trying out new ideas.

Information Collection

This unit systematically collects information on

- competitors
- customers
- economic and social trends
- technological trends

This unit frequently compares its performance with that of

- competitors
- best-in-class organizations

Analysis

This unit engages in productive conflict and debate during discussions.

This unit seeks out dissenting views during discussions.

This unit never revisits well-established perspectives during discussions.*

This unit frequently identifies and discusses underlying assumptions that might affect key decisions.

This unit never pays attention to different views during discussions.*

Education and Training

Newly hired employees in this unit receive adequate training.

Experienced employees in this unit receive

- periodic training and training updates
- training when switching to a new position
- training when new initiatives are launched

In this unit, training is valued.

In this unit, time is made available for education and training activities.

Information Transfer

This unit has forums for meeting with and learning from

- experts from other departments, teams, or divisions
- experts from outside the organization
- customers and clients
- suppliers

This unit regularly shares information with networks of experts within the organization.

This unit regularly shares information with networks of experts outside the organization.

This unit quickly and accurately communicates new knowledge to key decision makers.

This unit regularly conducts post-audits and after-action reviews.

BUILDING BLOCK 3

Leadership That Reinforces Learning

My managers invite input from others in discussions.

My managers acknowledge their own limitations with respect to knowledge, information, or expertise.

My managers ask probing questions.

My managers listen attentively.

My managers encourage multiple points of view.

My managers provide time, resources, and venues for identifying problems and organizational challenges.

My managers provide time, resources, and venues for reflecting and improving on past performance.

My managers criticize views different from their own.*

* Reverse-scored items

Source: Garvin, Edmondson & Gino (2008)

Benchmark Scores for the Learning Organization Survey

Building Blocks and Their Subcomponents	Scaled Scores				
	Bottom quartile	Second quartile	Median	Third quartile	Top quartile
Supportive Learning Environment					
• Psychological safety	31–66	67–75	76	77–86	87–100
• Appreciation of differences	14–56	57–63	64	65–79	80–100
• Openness to new ideas	38–80	81–89	90	91–95	96–100
• Time for reflection	14–35	36–49	50	51–64	65–100
Learning environment composite	31–61	62–70	71	72–79	80–90
Concrete Learning Processes and Practices					
• Experimentation	18–53	54–70	71	72–82	83–100
• Information collection	23–70	71–79	80	81–89	90–100
• Analysis	19–56	57–70	71	72–86	87–100
• Education and training	26–68	69–79	80	81–89	90–100
• Information transfer	34–60	61–70	71	72–84	85–100
Learning processes composite	31–62	63–73	74	75–82	83–97
Leadership That Reinforces Learning					
Composite for this block	33–66	67–75	76	77–82	83–100

Note: The scaled scores for learning environment and learning processes were computed by multiplying each raw score on the seven-point scale by 100 and dividing it by seven. For learning leadership, which was based on a five-point scale, the divisor was five.

Source: Garvin, Edmondson & Gino (2008)

Are you a leader who supports a healthy failure culture?

How much of what you usually hear is:

This?	Versus This?
Good news	Bad news
Progress	Problems
Agreement	Dissent
All's well	I need help

Source: Edmondson (2023)


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A Way to Learn
A Mark to Make
A World to Change